

What's Next?

The rapid strides that mobile phone technology has taken caught everyone by surprise. It is not that the technology's potential was not predicted; it is the sheer speed with which it is growing. If you were to travel back in time to 1995 and tell someone what the state of cell phones would be 15 years hence, they would laugh you off and call you a lunatic. Did any of us really think that we would be carry in our pocket a fully functional computer that doubles up as a communications device, multimedia player or photography tool as the need arises?

After all this, it is still being called a fledgling technology. Industry watchers predict that these handsets will become one-point access guides to every single aspect of our lives. Electronics heavyweights such as Microsoft, IBM and Sony have long talked of and spent millions of dollars towards creating the perfect 'convergence device' – a gadget that becomes the "One ring to rule them all" as reality gets augmented by technologies. Increasingly, it seems as if the technological platform for this 'one ring' is the cellular phone. And yes, that pun was too irresistible to omit.

It is said that to know the future, one must look on the present and the past; that all events are a pattern that can be predicted by those who have the knowledge of 'now'. So instead of relying on our trusty crystal ball in the smoke-filled dark room, we collected our thoughts about the most promising upcoming technologies to try and catch a glimpse of the future of mobile computing.

3.1 – Google Android

Industry watchers are unanimous in their verdict that Google's entry into the cellular world with its own operating system, Android, will be marked as a turning point for mobile phones in the history books of future generations.

We still remember when the announcement of the OS was first made by the Open Handset Alliance (OHA). Andy Rubin, the chief architect of Android, unveiled the mobile